

AI Readiness Checklist

15 Questions Every Leadership Team Should Ask Before Investing in AI

LearnedLate — AI Strategy-to-Execution Consultancy | learnedlate.com

How to Use This Checklist

Score each question on a 1–5 scale:

Score	Meaning
1	Not at all — we haven't started
2	Barely — early conversations only
3	Partially — some progress, significant gaps
4	Mostly — solid foundation, minor gaps
5	Fully — confident and operational

Add up your total at the end. Your score tells you where to focus before spending a dollar on AI tools.

Dimension 1: People

Skills, culture, and leadership commitment — the single biggest predictor of AI success or failure.

Q1. Do we have at least one senior leader who can dedicate meaningful time to championing AI initiatives?

AI projects without an executive sponsor rarely survive the first budget review. This person doesn't need to be technical — they need to own the outcome and maintain organizational commitment when challenges arise.

Score: ____ / 5

Q2. Does our team have sufficient AI literacy to evaluate opportunities and risks realistically?

You don't need a team of data scientists. You need people who can distinguish hype from practical capability, ask the right questions of vendors, and make informed build-vs-buy decisions.

Score: ____ / 5

Q3. Is our organization's culture open to changing established workflows based on AI recommendations?

The best AI system in the world fails if staff find workarounds, managers can't supervise new processes, or incentive structures contradict adoption. Resistance isn't irrational — it's a signal that change management matters.

Score: ____ / 5

Q4. Do we have a plan for upskilling staff who will work alongside AI systems daily?

30–40% of a successful AI implementation budget should go to people, not technology. Training, workflow redesign, and performance system adjustments are where adoption lives or dies.

Score: ____ / 5

People Subtotal: ____ / 20

Dimension 2: Process

Governance, workflows, and decision-making — where strategy meets operational reality.

Q5. Can we clearly articulate the specific business outcomes we expect from AI investments?

"We should use AI" is not a strategy. If you can't name the process to improve, the metric to move, and the dollar value at stake — you're not ready to invest. Outcome definition before technology selection is non-negotiable.

Score: ____ / 5

Q6. Have we mapped the actual workflows (not just the documented ones) of our highest-volume processes?

Most organisations have official process documentation and real process behaviour — and they don't match. AI designed against theory fails against reality. Workflow mapping is the step most consultants skip and most implementations regret.

Score: ____ / 5

Q7. Do we have a governance framework for evaluating, approving, and monitoring AI initiatives?

Who decides which AI projects proceed? Who monitors performance? Who intervenes when output quality drifts? Without governance, organisations accumulate disconnected experiments that never scale.

Score: ____ / 5

Q8. Can we run a focused pilot — one bounded process, validated against real metrics within 90 days?

The most common failure mode is starting too big. The antidote: pick one high-volume, clearly bounded process, build a working prototype within 2 weeks, and validate it within 90 days. If you can't do this organisationally, larger initiatives will stall.

Score: ____ / 5

Process Subtotal: ____ / 20

Dimension 3: Technology

Infrastructure, integration capability, and security — the foundation AI systems run on.

Q9. Do our current systems have APIs or integration points that would allow AI tools to access necessary data?

AI tools that can't connect to existing systems create parallel workflows instead of replacing them. If staff must manually bridge AI output back into core systems, efficiency gains evaporate. Integration capability is a hard prerequisite.

Score: ____ / 5

Q10. Is our IT infrastructure capable of supporting AI workloads (cloud access, compute capacity, security)?

This doesn't require massive investment. Cloud platforms provide scalable AI infrastructure on demand. But you need a clear picture of current capabilities, constraints, and the gap between where you are and where you need to be.

Score: ____ / 5

Q11. Do we have security and compliance frameworks that can accommodate AI data processing?

AI systems process organisational data — sometimes sensitive data — at scale. Privacy controls, access management, audit trails, and regulatory compliance aren't optional add-ons. They're foundational.

Score: ____ / 5

Q12. Can we evaluate AI vendors independently — without letting vendor capabilities shape our requirements?

Vendor-led strategy is the second most common AI failure mode. When the vendor leads the conversation, the answer is always their product — regardless of your actual needs. You need defined requirements before vendor engagement.

Score: ____ / 5

Technology Subtotal: ____ / 20

Dimension 4: Data

Quality, accessibility, and governance — the raw material AI runs on.

Q13. Do we have historical data that could be used to train or validate AI models for our use cases?

AI needs data to learn from. If your target process has no recorded history, inconsistent records, or data locked in formats AI can't read, you have a data problem to solve before an AI problem to solve.

Score: ____ / 5

Q14. Is our critical business data accessible from a single point, or fragmented across disconnected systems?

Data fragmented across spreadsheets, legacy systems, inboxes, and paper files is the reality for most organisations. Knowing the state of your data — where it lives, what format it's in, and what's missing — is the first step. Many organisations discover this mid-project, when it's expensive to fix.

Score: ____ / 5

Q15. Do we have data governance policies covering quality standards, access controls, and retention?

Who owns the data? Who can access it? How is quality maintained? What are the retention rules? Without data governance, AI systems inherit and amplify existing data problems — producing confident-sounding outputs from unreliable inputs.

Score: ____ / 5

Data Subtotal: ____ / 15

Your Score

Dimension	Your Score	Maximum
People	—	20
Process	—	20
Technology	—	20
Data	—	15
Total	—	75

What Your Score Means

60–75: Ready to Move

You have strong foundations. The risk isn't readiness — it's delay. Every quarter competitors build AI capability is a quarter you fall further behind. Focus on selecting the right initial project, not more preparation.

Recommended next step: Book an AI Readiness Assessment to identify your highest-ROI starting point.

40–59: Foundations in Place, Gaps to Close

You have real strengths to build on, but specific gaps that would derail implementation if ignored. The good news: these gaps are addressable in weeks, not months. The bad news: most organisations skip this step and pay for it later.

Recommended next step: Identify your lowest-scoring dimension. That's where to invest before committing to AI implementation.

20–39: Preparation Required

Jumping into AI implementation now carries high failure risk. This isn't a reason to wait indefinitely — it's a reason to prepare deliberately. Targeted investment in your weakest dimensions will dramatically improve implementation success probability.

Recommended next step: Start with a focused readiness assessment to build a practical preparation plan with clear milestones.

Below 20: Start with the Basics

AI is not your most urgent priority. Focus first on foundational capabilities — data management, process documentation, technology modernisation — that will serve you regardless of AI plans. When you're ready, the opportunity will still be there.

The Context Behind These Questions

These aren't theoretical. They're drawn from documented patterns across hundreds of AI implementations in the ANZ market:

- **87%** of NZ organisations report using some form of AI

- **12%** have successfully scaled it across their operations
- **95%** of enterprise AI pilots fail to deliver measurable business value
- **32%** cite skills shortages as their primary barrier
- **22%** cite data quality and integration issues

The gap between experimentation and transformation is where most organisations are stuck. This checklist helps you understand why — and what to do about it.

Want to Go Deeper?

This checklist gives you a snapshot. Our **free AI Readiness Assessment** gives you a scored evaluation across all four dimensions, a prioritised opportunity map, and specific recommendations — delivered in a 30-minute conversation with a written summary within 48 hours.

Book your free assessment: learnedlate.com/contact

No pressure, no obligation — just clarity on where you stand and what path forward makes sense.

LearnedLate — AI Strategy-to-Execution Consultancy Serving New Zealand & Australia learnedlate.com